

Progressive Sanctification

doc-progressive-sanctification

Soteriology · Sanctification · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Sanctification is the progressive, Spirit-wrought work of conforming believers to the image of Christ; distinct from justification but inseparable from it; engaged through means of grace and Spirit-empowered effort.

In plain language

The Greek words behind this doctrine point in one direction when you look at their grammar. In 2 Corinthians 3:18 the verb is 'we are being transformed' (metamorphoumetha), a present tense and passive form (ongoing action done to us), so the change is continuous and is done to us, here by the Spirit, as we move from glory to glory into the same 'image' (eikon). The same kind of present participle appears in Colossians 3:10, 'the new self being renewed' (anakainoumenon) according to the image of its creator. The word for grow in 2 Peter 3:18, 'keep growing' (auxanete) in grace, is a present command, and that verb is mostly continuous all through the New Testament. The noun usually translated 'sanctification' or 'holiness' (hagiasmos) shows up as a goal you move toward: Romans 6:19 and 6:22 say the body and its fruit are offered unto holiness, and Hebrews 12:14 makes it the object of a present command, 'keep pursuing' (diokete) it. Philippians 2:12 and 13 hold two things in one breath, a present command to keep working out your salvation with fear and trembling, and the reason, God is the one at work in you ('the one working', energon) to will and to do. So human striving and divine power are not rivals; the striving happens because God is working underneath it. Philippians 1:6 frames the whole thing as begun and to be completed at the day of Christ. The honest wrinkle is that the verb 'to sanctify' (hagiazō) also appears in finished forms: 'you were sanctified' (hegiasthete, an aorist or completed past action) in 1 Corinthians 6:11, and 'we have been sanctified' (hegiasthēn, a perfect, a completed action whose result still stands) in Hebrews 10:10. Yet just four verses later Hebrews 10:14 uses the ongoing form, 'those being sanctified' (hagiazomenoi), of the same people. So one book places the completed sense and the in-progress sense right next to each other. That is the root of any confusion here: a single word family carries both a settled standing and an ongoing work, and the text never ranks one over the other. Read together, the present-tense, Spirit-empowered, effort-engaged transformation described in the proposition is plainly present across these books.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0037	ἀγιάζω	hagiazō	to sanctify	28
G0038	ἁγιασμός	hagiasmos	holiness	10
G0837	αὐξάνω	auxano	to grow	23
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	170
G1504	εἰκών	eikon	image	23
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeo	be active	21

G1939	ἐπιθυμία	epithymia	desire	38
G2005	ἐπιτελέω	epiteleō	to complete	10
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2716	κατεργάζομαι	katērgazomai	to workout/produce	22
G3196	μέλος	melos	member	34
G3339	μεταμορφόομαι	metamorphoomai	to transform	4
G3696	ὄπλον	hoplon	weapon	6
G3936	παρίστημι	paristemi	to stand by	43
G4202	πορνεία	porneia	sexual sin	26
G4234	πράξις	praxis	action	6
G5219	ὑπακούω	hypakouō	to obey	21

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition is carried by verbal aspect (the angle of time the verb takes, such as ongoing versus completed). The verb 'to be transformed' (metamorphoo, G3339) appears in its non-transfiguration uses only in the present passive (action being received continuously): 2 Corinthians 3:18 has 'we are being transformed' (metamorphooumetha, V-PPI-1P, a present passive indicative, meaning ongoing action done to us) into the same 'image' (eikon, G1504) from glory to glory; and Romans 12:2 has 'be transformed' (metamorphousthe, V-PPM-2P, a present passive imperative), a durative passive (an ongoing form where the action is received) that marks ongoing Spirit-wrought change rather than a completed act. The verb 'to grow' (auxano, G0837) is dominantly present and imperfect (ongoing or repeated past action) across the canon and stands as a present imperative in 2 Peter 3:18 'keep growing' (auxanete). The noun 'sanctification' or 'holiness' (hagiasmos, G0038) is governed by the preposition 'unto' (eis) in Romans 6:19 and 6:22, holiness as a terminus moved toward, and is the object of the present imperative 'pursue' (diokete) in Hebrews 12:14. Philippians 2:12 and 13 pairs the present imperative 'keep working out' (katēgazesthe, V-PNM-2P) with 'God the one working' (theos ho energon, G1754, present participle), and Philippians 1:6 draws the arc from 'having begun' (enarxamenos, aorist, a completed past action) to 'will complete' (epiteleseis, V-FAI-3S). The genuine complication is that the cognate verb 'to sanctify' (hagiazō, G0037) carries both a definitive aorist (a completed past action) or perfect sense (a completed action whose result still stands), as in 1 Corinthians 6:11 'you were sanctified' (hegiasthete) and Hebrews 10:10 'we have been sanctified' (hegiasthētoi), and a present durative sense (ongoing) in the same context, as in Hebrews 10:14 'those being sanctified' (hagiazomenoi) and Hebrews 2:11. The canon supplies both aspects without ranking them, so the present-tense pattern establishes the progressive work while the aorist and perfect establish a settled standing, which the proposition affirms together rather than against.

Scripture

1Thess.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0038 ἁγιασμός, G4202 πορνεία

Force. 'For this is the will of God, your sanctification' (touto gar estin thelema tou theou, ho hagiasmos hymon). The noun 'sanctification' (hagiasmos, G0038, N-NSM, a noun in the subject form) is equated with the divine will and is then unpacked by the present middle infinitive 'to keep abstaining' (apechesthai, V-PMN) from 'sexual immorality' (porneia, G4202). The grammar presents holiness as a willed ongoing condition expressed in sustained conduct, not a single past event.

Rom.6.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0038 ἁγιασμός, G3936 παρίστημι

Force. The aorist imperative 'present' (parastesate, V-AAM-2P, a one-time command in the past-completed form) of the members as slaves to righteousness 'unto sanctification' (eis hagianmon, G0038, N-ASM, in the direct-object form) sets holiness as the terminus of the offering. The preposition 'unto' (eis) marks 'sanctification' (hagiasmos) as a goal moved toward, contrasted with the prior aorist 'you presented' (parestesate) that described the old enslavement to impurity, so the noun names a direction of ongoing reorientation.

Rom.6.22 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0038 ἁγιασμός

Force. Having been freed from sin, the aorist passive participle 'having been freed' (eleutherothentes, V-APP-NPM, a past-completed action received), and enslaved to God, the present indicative 'you are having' (echete, V-PAI-2P, ongoing simple statement), you are having your fruit 'unto sanctification' (eis hagianmon, G0038, N-ASM). The settled past freeing yields present, continuing fruit whose direction is 'sanctification' (hagiasmos), again with 'unto' (eis) marking it as an outcome being moved toward, not a finished transaction.

Heb.12.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0038 ἁγιασμός

Force. 'Pursue' (diokete, V-PAM-2P, a present imperative, meaning 'keep pursuing') governs 'the sanctification' (ton hagianmon, G0038, N-ASM) as its object. The same noun that 1 Thessalonians 4:3 calls the will of God and Romans 6:19 and 6:22 sets as a terminus here becomes the object of continuous pursuit, the verb of chasing marking holiness as something still to be sought rather than already possessed in full.

2Cor.3.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3339 μεταμορφόομαι, G1504 εἰκών, G1391 δόξα

Force. 'We are being transformed' (metamorphoumetha, G3339, V-PPI-1P) is present tense and passive (ongoing action received from outside), durative action received from outside the self, into the same 'image' (eikon, G1504) and proceeding 'from glory to glory' (apo doxes eis doxan, G1391), 'from the Lord the Spirit' (apo kyriou pneumatou). The accompanying present middle participle 'beholding or reflecting' (katoptrizomenoi, V-PMP-NPM) is likewise ongoing. The morphology of 'to be transformed' (metamorphoo), attested elsewhere only as a present in Romans 12:2 and as past transfiguration aorists (completed past forms), encodes progression and Spirit-wrought agency here.

Phil.2.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2716 κατεργάζομαι, G5219 ὑπακούω

Force. 'Keep working out' (katergazesthe, G2716, V-PNM-2P) is a present imperative, addressed to those who have already 'obeyed' (hupəkousate, G5219, aorist, a completed past action), framed 'with fear and trembling' (meta phobou kai tromou). The present aspect (ongoing) marks sustained effort rather than a finished work, locating real and continuing human engagement inside an already-given salvation.

Phil.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1754 ἐνεργέω, G2316 θεός

Force. 'For God is the one working in you' (theos gar estin ho energon, G1754, V-PAP-NSM, present active participle, ongoing) grounds the preceding imperative with the explanatory 'for' (gar). The present participle 'working' (energon) governs both 'the willing' (to thelein) and 'the working' (to energein, V-PAN, present active infinitive). Divine agency stands underneath the human effort of verse 12 without cancelling it, holding sovereign working and Spirit-empowered effort together in a single causal clause.

Phil.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2005 ἐπιτελέω

Force. 'The one having begun' (ho enarxamenos, V-ADP-NSM, aorist participle meaning a completed past start) 'in you a good work will complete' (en hymin ergon agathon epitelesei, G2005, V-FAI-3S, future active indicative) 'until the day of Christ Jesus' (achri hemeras Christou Iesou). The aorist (completed past action) of beginning and the future of completing bracket a single divine work that runs between conversion and the day of Christ, the verbal aspects framing sanctification as a process underway between two endpoints rather than a finished state.

Rom.6.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3936 παρίστημι, G3196 μέλος, G3696 ὄπλον

Force. The verse sets the present imperative 'keep presenting' (paristanete, G3936, V-PAM-2P) against the aorist imperative 'present once' (parastesate, V-AAM-2P, a one-time past-completed command) of the 'members' (mele, G3196) as 'weapons' or 'instruments' (hopla, G3696). The present forbids ongoing surrender of the body to sin while the aorist (completed past action) calls for a decisive yielding to God. The two aspects together describe a sustained reorientation that follows from being reckoned alive in verse 11, where 'reckon' (logizesthe) is itself a present imperative.

Rom.8.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4234 πράξις

Force. 'If by the Spirit the deeds of the body you are putting to death' (ei pneumatī tas praxeis, G4234, tou somatos thanatoute). The verb 'you are putting to death' (thanatoute, V-PAI-2P, present active indicative, an ongoing simple statement of fact) is present, marking continuous action, and the dative (the 'to/with-X' grammatical form) 'by the Spirit' (pneumatī) names the empowering agent. Human action and Spirit empowerment are coordinated within one conditional clause (an 'if-then' clause) that governs whether one 'will live' (zesesthe, V-FDI-2P, future deponent indicative).

Col.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3196 μέλος, G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G4202 πορνεία

Force. 'Put to death' (nekrosate, V-AAM-2P, aorist imperative, a decisive past-completed command) is directed at the 'members' (mele, G3196) upon the earth, itemized as 'sexual immorality' (porneia, G4202), 'evil desire' (epithymia kaken, G1939) and the rest. The aorist (completed past action) commands a decisive mortification, while the surrounding present-tense putting off in verses 8 and 9, 'put away' and 'do not lie' (apothesthe, me pseudesthe, V-PNM-2P), shows the same struggle continuing. The command presupposes a new standing yet calls for action against remaining sin, the put-off side of transformation.

Col.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1504 εἰκών

Force. 'The new self being renewed' (ton neon ton anakainoumenon, V-PPP-ASM, a present passive participle, ongoing action received), is a present passive participle marking renewal in process, 'unto knowledge according to the image of its creator' (eis epignosin kat eikona, G1504, tou ktisantos). The same 'image' (eikon) target as 2 Corinthians 3:18 reappears with a durative passive (ongoing-received) renewal verb, confirming progressive conformity to a pattern as something done to the believer over time.

2Pet.3.18 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0837 αὐξάνω

Force. 'Keep growing' (auxanete, G0837, V-PAM-2P, a present imperative) in grace and knowledge of the Lord Jesus Christ. The verb of organic growth, attested across the canon dominantly in present and imperfect (ongoing or repeated past) forms, here stands as a sustained command. Growth in grace is presented as an ongoing imperative directed at believers, the increase metaphor reinforcing the durative (ongoing) pattern of the transformation verbs.

1Cor.6.11 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0037 ἁγιάζω

Force. 'You were sanctified' (hegiasthete, G0037, V-API-2P, aorist passive indicative) is aorist (a completed past action), set beside 'you were washed' (apelousasthe) and 'you were justified' (edikaiothete), all marking a decisive past act. This aorist of 'to sanctify' (hagiazō) establishes a settled position. It is the complementary definitive datum to the present-aspect (ongoing) forms, and it does not cancel the durative pattern but stands alongside it.

Heb.10.14 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0037 ἁγιάζω

Force. By one offering he has perfected forever 'those being sanctified' (eis to dienekeis tous hagiazomenous, G0037, V-PPP-APM, present passive participle in the direct-object form, ongoing action received). The present passive participle marks an ongoing class who are in the process of being sanctified, standing four verses after the perfect 'we have been sanctified' (hegiasmenoi, a completed action whose result still stands) of verse 10. Hebrews thus places a completed perfect and a durative present of the same verb in immediate proximity, showing the two aspects coexist within one argument.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Col.3.10	Ps.51.10	tsk	1
Col.3.10	Ezek.11.19	tsk	1
Col.3.10	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Phil.2.13	1Kgs.8.58	tsk	1
Phil.2.12	Phil.3.13	tsk	1
Rom.6.13	Rom.12.1	tsk	1
1Thess.4.3	1Thess.5.18	tsk	1
Heb.12.14	Heb.12.10	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.6.11 · addressed

1 Corinthians 6:11 uses the aorist 'you were sanctified' (hegiasthete, G0037, V-API-2P, aorist passive indicative, a completed past action received), beside 'you were washed' and 'you were justified', marking a decisive past act and a settled position. It complicates an exclusively process reading, but the present-tense durative (ongoing) forms 'we are being transformed' (metamorphoumetha), 'being renewed' (anakainoumenon), 'those being sanctified' (hagiazomenous), and 'keep growing' (auxanete) remain in force in other texts. The verb 'to sanctify' (hagiazō) demonstrably carries both aspects, so the aorist establishes standing while the present establishes the ongoing work, which the proposition affirms together by distinguishing sanctification from justification yet binding them.

Heb.10.10 · addressed

Hebrews 10:10 uses the perfect 'we have been sanctified' (hegiasmenoi esmen, G0037, V-RPP-NPM, perfect passive participle plus 'we are', a completed action whose result still stands), a completed state grounded in Christ's one offering. Four verses later Hebrews 10:14 uses the present 'those being sanctified' (hagiazomenous, V-PPP-APM, ongoing action received) of the same group, and Hebrews 2:11 again uses the present 'those being sanctified' (hagiazomenoi). The same book places the completed perfect and the durative present of one verb side by side, which is direct lexical evidence that the definitive and progressive senses coexist rather than compete, exactly the both-and the proposition asserts.

1Thess.5.23 · addressed

1 Thessalonians 5:23 uses 'may he sanctify' (hagiasai, G0037, V-AAO-3S, aorist active optative, a wish in the completed-past form), may God himself sanctify you 'wholly' (holokleron), with the second coming (parousia) in view. This is a punctiliar prayer (a one-time, point-in-time prayer) for completed sanctification at the end, not a present process verb. It does not contradict progression but names its goal and final consummation, the same began-to-complete arc as Philippians 1:6, so the present-aspect verbs describe the road and this verse the destination.

Concordance traversed

G0038, G0037, G3339, G0837, G1504, G1391, G1754, G2716, G2005, G1939, G3196, G3936, G5219, G4202, G4234, G3696

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units exist in the lexical store for any cited verse. The ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) covers only 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, and all anchor texts fall outside that window, so the verses are treated as ecm-shadow (sitting outside the published critical edition's window) rather than ecm-published. The decisive verbal forms 'we are being transformed' (metamorphoumetha), 'keep working out' (katargazesthe), 'the one working' (energon), 'sanctification' (hagiasmos), 'pursue' (diokete), 'keep growing' (auxanete), and the mortification imperatives are textually stable in the standard apparatus, so the verdict does not turn on any variant.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

definitive_sanctification_lens: affirms with reordering · A reading that foregrounds the aorist 'you were sanctified' (hegiasthete, a completed past action) of 1 Corinthians 6:11 and the perfect 'we have been sanctified' (hegiasmenoi, a completed action whose result still stands) of Hebrews 10:10 treats sanctification primarily as a settled position established once at conversion. On its strongest form this lens reads holiness as a status the believer already has in Christ, and the present-tense verbs as the outworking of that fixed standing rather than a separate ongoing acquisition. Even on this lens the present durative (ongoing) forms 'we are being transformed' (metamorphoumetha, 2 Corinthians 3:18), 'being renewed' (anakainoumenon, Colossians 3:10), 'those being sanctified' (hagiazomenous, Hebrews 10:14), and the present imperative 'keep growing' (auxanete, 2 Peter 3:18) require a real ongoing transformative dimension, so the proposition holds, with the definitive sense given logical priority.

monergistic_emphasis_lens: affirms · A lens stressing divine agency reads 'God the one working' (theos ho energon, G1754) of Philippians 2:13 and the passive 'we are being transformed' (metamorphoumetha) of 2 Corinthians 3:18 as making God the sole effective cause of the change. In its strongest form the human imperatives are the appointed means through which God works, not independent contributions. This lens still keeps the present imperatives 'keep working out' (katargazesthe), 'pursue' (diokete), 'put to death' (thanatoute), 'put to death' (nekrosate), and 'keep growing' (auxanete) intact as genuine commanded activity, which matches the proposition's Spirit-empowered effort clause.

completed_or_perfectionist_lens: partially affirms · A lens reading sanctification as already complete or attainable as a finished state in this life leans on the perfect 'we have been sanctified' (hegiasmenoi, Hebrews 10:10) and the aorist optative 'may he sanctify wholly' (hagiasai holoteleis, 1 Thessalonians 5:23) as evidence of an accomplished or instantaneous holiness. In its strongest form it treats the present verbs as describing experience rather than an incomplete work. The lexical difficulty for this lens is that 'pursue' (diokete, Hebrews 12:14) and 'keep growing' (auxanete, 2 Peter 3:18) are present imperatives addressed to believers who still must pursue and grow, and Philippians 1:6 sets completion at the future day of Christ, so the words locate full completion beyond the present, leaving the progressive sense standing.

The verdict rests on verbal aspect (the angle of time the verb takes, ongoing versus completed), tense, and voice read across several New Testament books together by analogy of Scripture (reading Scripture by Scripture). The lexical hinge is the aspect split within 'to sanctify' (hagiazō, G0037), present durative (ongoing) versus aorist (completed past action) and perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) definitive, attested side by side in Hebrews. Old Testament cross-references to a renewed heart in Psalm 51:10 and Ezekiel 11:19 supply conceptual background, but the case is carried by the New Testament morphology (word-form patterns).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition uses descriptive terms, progressive, Spirit-wrought, distinct from but inseparable from justification, means of grace and Spirit-empowered effort, that map onto observable lexical features, durative present tense (ongoing), passive voice (action received), paired human imperatives with divine working, and the 'unto'-marked (eis-marked) goal noun 'sanctification' (hagiasmos), rather than smuggling in one tradition's verdict. The verdict is derived on the original stem from queried morphology (word-form patterns). No change to the prior affirms: true was warranted; the present-aspect (ongoing) transformation and growth language is decisive and the definitive aorist (completed past action) and perfect (completed action whose result still stands) of 'to sanctify' (hagiazō) is a complementary, not contradictory, datum.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Cor.3.18
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Phil.2.12
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Phil.2.13
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Heb.10.14
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Heb.10.10
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.6.11
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Pet.3.18
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.6.19
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0038
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0037
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3339
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0837
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Col.3.10
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Heb.12.14
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Phil.2.12

License audit

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